MP elections, recalls being wonderstruck by how the PM connected with the crowds. He says, "Modi*ji* knows the pulse of the people and understands the social dynamics of the country very well. Each speech of his is filled with new ideas and he rarely repeats what he says in a rally." During these elections, Modi cleverly appropriated the Congress welfare guarantees that won it Karnataka by introducing what he called the "Modi *ki* Guarantee".

THE MODI GUARANTEE

With the PM leading from the front, the BJP won all three heartland states handsomely, puncturing the Congress party's growing electoral confidence. Modi is modest about his role saying, "Victory comes through the joint efforts of everyone. So it would be unfair to give me the credit. It belongs to our *karyakartas* and their hard work." Asked what the Modi Guarantee would be for the 2024 election, the prime minister turned serious and said, "For me, the guarantee is not mere words or election promises or a formula to win elections. When I talk of a guarantee, I bind myself to it. It doesn't let me sleep, it propels me to work harder, and it leads me to give my everything for the people. Today, every poor person is aware of how political parties in the past have broken their trust. But they all know that 'Modi's Guarantee' can be trusted." The PM then went on to use a telling Hindi phrase, saying, "*Makkhan par lakir toh sab karte hain. Karni hai to pathar par lakir karo. Kathin hai to kya hua, shuruat to kare* (It is easy to draw a line in butter, if you have to draw a line in stone it is hard, but let's make a beginning). This is what I believe in, which gives me the conviction to take on difficult tasks."

Is the 2024 General Election then a done deal for the BJP? In the interview, Modi seemed confident but said he and his party would have to work hard to ensure it. Indicating that his pitch would be for a stable and performance-oriented government, the prime minister revealed his dim view of the INDIA alliance, "There is a consensus among the people that the country doesn't need a *mili-juli sarkar* (coalition government). We have lost 30 years due to the instability resulting from such *sarkars*. People have seen the lack of governance, appeasement politics and corruption in the era of the *mili-juli sarkar*. So naturally the choice of the people is the BJP."

THE MENTOR

On party matters, Modi's avatar is that of The Mentor. Modi has made use of the recent victories to bring about a generational change in the BJP's leadership





The PM has the courage and conviction to break taboos of the past as he did in the space sector, says Jitendra Singh, his MoS for science and technology